Zewail City of Science and Technology

مدينة زويل للعلوم والتكنولوجيا

Sociology

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What Is Sociology?



Introduction:

- We are social beings who desire the company of others. In the process of being with others we learn about the world around us, we learn about ourselves, we learn how to interact, and we learn how to fit our inborn talents and skills into the existing milieu.

- You and I are born into a social world already in motion—our birth changes our family, but our family expects us to get with its program.
- You may have dreams of getting into a career and shaping an industry; however, in most cases, the impact that an industry or company will have on you will be greater than your impact is on it.

- Sociology is the study of human social life. It involves the study of groups and group interactions, from small and personal groups to very large groups and societies.
- Society refers to a population of people who live in a defined geographic area, share a common culture and identity, and are subject to the same political authority.

- The subject matter of psychology seems more relevant to our personal lives. The circumstances and events that occur in our lives appear to us to be caused by our individual choices.
- Moreover, psychology's subject matter (the individual) is tangible and therefore requires less abstract thought than is necessary to grasp the basic subject matter of sociology (interdependence).

The Rise of Sociology

- The rise of the study of society coincided with a series of historical events that focused thought among keen observers of social life on how individuals working in groups form, maintain, and change the social conditions under which they live.

- Pointing to the moment in time when a train of thought originates is a somewhat arbitrary process, but many social scientists agree that in the Western world, a fundamental shift in thinking about individualism, social relations, and the distribution of power in society occurred during a period of time known as the Enlightenment.

- From roughly 1600 to 1800, a wide-ranging number of thinkers took advantage of the relatively new technology of printing in order to write down and disseminate their ideas.
- The Enlightenment was not a coordinated social movement, but rather a dialogue held by a number of commentators about individualism, power, social relations, religion, education, and other matters.

Pioneers of Sociology

- The thinking of John Locke on rights in civil society, Voltaire on social reform, and others stimulated new thinking about freedom and the capacity of human beings to bring greater order and justice into the world.
- The thoughts that culminated in the period known as the Enlightenment contributed to the rise of systematic inquiry and the revolutions for freedom that occurred first in England, then in America, and, shortly afterward, in France.



- French philosopher August Comte (1798–1857) argued that a science of society was needed in order to observe and describe the social developments taking place in a systematic manner. Originally calling this new field of inquiry social physics, Comte later replaced that label with the one he coined: sociology.
- Sociology emerged as a legitimate field of study as intellectuals began to recognize that, through systematic inquiry, one could acquire a clearer understanding of the factors that shape social life.

- The seminal works of Durkheim, Marx, Weber, and Simmel show how factors, both external to and between individuals, profoundly affect the choices that individuals make.
- For example, by examining suicide rates in different cities in Europe, Durkheim was able to explain why suicide was more likely in some places than in others. He showed that the underlying factor explaining suicide rates is not depression, but rather the degree to which people feel connected to each other.

- In communities where social bonds are strong, an individual is much less likely to take his or her own life.
- Marx explicated how those with wealth shape the priorities of everyone in a culture.
- In contemporary terms, a person with wealth has a much easier time gaining access to media to promote particular ideas or products. Paying a celebrity to commercialize the message or product can enhance widespread appeal even more.

- Weber coined the term social action to explain how people adjust their behaviors to each other. For example, in the morning as you prepare for your day, you are very likely to take into consideration what your schedule entails and who you are likely to see.
- Choices will differ depending upon whether your day will include hanging out with your best friend, going for a job interview, or attending a family gathering. In each case, we orient our individual behavior in different ways in order to meet social expectations.

- Simmel pointed out how the number of members in a group influences each of the participants. A group of two involves greater expectations upon each member in order for the group to continue than does a group of three or four. However, with greater expectations usually come more opportunities to establish meaningful interpersonal bonds.
- In general, the larger the size of the group, the easier it is to avoid feeling a sense of responsibility for the maintenance of the group; yet simultaneously, the bigger the group, the more readily the feeling of personal insignificance arises.

Ibn Khaldūn

- Ibn Khaldun’s original intention, which he subsequently achieved, was to write a universal history of the Arabs, but before doing so he judged it necessary to discuss historical method, with the aim of providing the criteria necessary for distinguishing historical truth from error.



- This led him to formulate what the 20th-century English historian Arnold Toynbee has described as “a philosophy of history which is undoubtedly the greatest work of its kind that has ever yet been created by any mind in any time or place.”
- His study of the nature of society and social change led him to evolve what he clearly saw was a new science, which he called ʿilm al-ʿumrān (“the science of culture”) .

ASSUMPTIONS OF THE SOCIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVE

- There are three key assumptions underlying the sociological perspective of society.
- **The first assumption** is that human beings are social animals.
- Our growth and development as individual human beings is contingent upon social conditions and relationships.

- According to many sociologists, anthropologists, and evolutionary psychologists, this heightened capacity to organize our behavior in groups has had a tremendous impact on our ability to survive and thrive as a species.
- Our social nature is clearly evident in the mother-infant relationship. Human infants are among the most helpless creatures born into existence. Most other mammals are walking shortly after birth. A human infant cannot even turn itself over, and it takes months before a baby can hold up its own head. Without constant and enduring care, a human baby cannot survive.

- **The second assumption** is that individuals working in groups create, maintain, and change the social factors that govern their lives.
- **The third assumption** is that, although social patterns (i.e., customs, forms of exchange, etc.) are established by the coordination of individual efforts, over time these social practices are experienced as obligatory.

How Individuals Maintain and Change Society

- The social world is made up of individuals engaged in social interactions. These interactions form social groups, which form the institutions of society.
- Social institutions include economy, political system, education, religion, and the military. Once formed, social institutions take on a life of their own—they tend to endure beyond the years of the individuals, who, at any given time, comprise them.

- However, because individuals create social institutions and maintain them through their interactions, they may also change them via their interactions.
- Sociologist Peter L. Berger (1963) referred to this process as the paradox of social existence. Essentially, as society creates us, we create society.

- While one person cannot change a society, many persons working together can and do change a society.
- When a critical mass of people envisions another possibility for their society (whether or not they are aware of using the sociological imagination), change happens.
- The leaders of change, such as Martin Luther King, do not single-handedly alter the beliefs and practices of society. A leader is a focal point for a group. Without a group there can be no leader.

The Case of Rosa Parks

- Black people constituted a majority of bus riders in Montgomery from the very beginnings of the service in 20th century. According to the Women's Political Council, a Montgomery-based advocacy group, "three-fourths of the riders" on Montgomery buses were Black.
- Despite this, the front rows on each Montgomery bus were reserved for white passengers, while the back rows were designated for Black passengers.

- On December 1, 1955, Rosa Parks boarded a bus in Montgomery, Alabama. Instead of going to the back of the bus, which was designated for African Americans, she sat in the front. When the bus started to fill up with white passengers, the bus driver asked Parks to move. She refused. Her resistance set in motion one of the largest social movements in history, the Montgomery Bus Boycott.

- Parks courageous act and the subsequent Montgomery Bus Boycott led to the integration of public transportation in Montgomery. Her actions were not without consequence. She was jailed for refusing to give up her seat and lost her job for participating in the boycott.

Parks revealed her true motivation years later:

“People always say that I didn’t give up my seat because I was tired, but that isn’t true. I was not tired physically, or no more tired than I usually was at the end of a working day. I was not old, although some people have an image of me as being old then. I was forty-two. No, the only tired I was, was tired of giving in.”



The Montgomery Bus Boycott

- The Montgomery bus boycott was a 13-month mass protest against racial segregation on public transit in Montgomery, Alabama. Sparked by Rosa Parks's December 1955 arrest for refusing to surrender her seat to a white passenger.

- For 381 days, around 50,000 Black residents boycotted the system. They sustained the movement by walking, carpooling, organizing volunteer taxi networks, and using horse-drawn buggies.
- The Resolution: The boycott crippled the bus company's revenue and prompted severe segregationist pushback, including mass arrests. The protest finally ended after the U.S. Supreme Court ruled that segregation on public transportation is unconstitutional.
- Montgomery Bus Boycott was a foundational event in the US Civil Rights Movement and an example of peaceful resistance.

Peaceful Resistance

- Also widely known as nonviolent resistance or civil resistance, is the practice of achieving socio-political goals through symbolic protests, economic or political noncooperation, civil disobedience, and other methods while completely abstaining from physical violence.

Other Historical Examples

- The Salt March (1930): Led by Mahatma Gandhi to protest the British salt monopoly in India.
- The Velvet Revolution (1989): A non-violent transition of power in Czechoslovakia that ended the communist regime.

"Be the change that you wish to see in the world."

– Mahatma Gandhi

Thanks!